

Daoism



The Chinese character for Dao, 'the way', used as a symbol of Daoism.

One of the primary concerns for the dynastic states of China in the sixth century BCE was to establish a system of government that reflected traditional religious ideas. A class of scholars with civic responsibilities had emerged, and among them was Laozi (or Lao Tzu), who proposed a comprehensive moral philosophy as a basis for social and political organization. This view of the world subsequently became known as Daoism. Laozi started from a belief that the ever-changing world was made

up of complementary states: light and dark, night and day, life and death, each arising from the other in a cyclical fashion and in eternal harmony and balance. These '10,000 manifestations' form the process of change known as *dao*, 'the way', characterized by 'not-being' and beyond human understanding. We disturb the cosmic balance if we stray from the *dao* by giving in to desire, ambition or social convention; to live in accordance with the *dao*, we must adopt a life of 'non-action', a simple and tranquil life in harmony with nature, behaving intuitively and thoughtfully, not impulsively.